GABRIEL POPA

Senior Software Engineer - Java (Spring Boot) • AWS

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ABOUT ME

Senior Software Engineer with 10+ years of experience building business platforms, workflow-heavy applications, and API-driven systems with a strong focus on **Java backend engineering**, service design, data-intensive processing, and production reliability. Strongest work centers on modernizing legacy systems, stabilizing difficult production issues, delivering secure backend features, and supporting phased migrations from older monolithic or mixed-service implementations into cleaner **Spring Boot** architectures. Hands-on across **Java 8–21**, **Spring Framework 4.x–6.x**, **Spring Boot 1.x–3.x**, **Hibernate 4.x–6.x**, and SQL-based systems, with solid depth in **REST APIs**, **authentication**, **query tuning**, **Docker**, **Azure**, testing, and safe step-by-step upgrade work across actively used platforms.

SKILLS

- **Backend: Java 8–21**, **Spring Framework 4.x–6.x**, **Spring Boot 1.x–3.x**, Spring MVC, Spring Data JPA, Hibernate 4.x–6.x, REST API design, backend modularization, service-layer architecture, validation, background jobs, integration services, authentication, authorization
- **Data & Messaging: SQL Server**, **PostgreSQL**, **MySQL**, **Redis**, schema design, query tuning, indexing, stored procedures, pagination, caching, queue-based processing, event-driven integration basics
- **Cloud & DevOps: Azure App Service**, **Azure Functions**, **Azure SQL**, Blob Storage, Azure DevOps, Docker, Kubernetes basics, Git, GitHub Actions, Jenkins, CI/CD pipelines, Linux, Nginx, IIS, release automation, deployment troubleshooting
- **Observability / Quality / Security:** JUnit, Mockito, integration testing, API testing, structured logging, **OpenTelemetry basics**, Prometheus/Grafana basics, Sentry, JWT, RBAC, OWASP security practices, rate limiting, error monitoring

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Senior Software Engineer

Soft Build | Bucharest, Romania *(Jan 2024 – May 2026)*

- Delivered a multi-module business platform using **Java 17–21**, **Spring Boot 3.x**, REST APIs, and SQL-backed workflows, turning fragmented operational requirements into stable backend services for approvals, reporting, administration, and high-traffic dashboard processing.
- Modernized older service implementations into a cleaner **Spring Boot 3.x** structure with slimmer controllers, clearer service boundaries, centralized validation, and safer dependency configuration, which reduced maintenance friction and improved delivery confidence for ongoing feature work.
- Designed and expanded backend modules for role-sensitive administration, reporting pipelines, and operational state transitions, helping business teams move away from manual handoffs and into more predictable API-driven workflows.
- Diagnosed a recurring timeout problem on large dashboard requests by tracing slow repository access, trimming oversized payloads, refining query paths, and introducing targeted pagination, which stabilized service behavior under heavier concurrent usage.
- Built secure API flows with **JWT**-based authentication, permission-aware service checks, and cleaner error responses, which improved control over sensitive operations and reduced access-related support cases across shared business modules.
- Stabilized a difficult export issue that failed on large datasets by replacing memory-heavy generation logic with streamed processing and safer batching, which improved reliability for finance and operational reporting scenarios.
- Added structured logging and basic **OpenTelemetry** instrumentation around critical request paths, making root-cause analysis faster during intermittent production issues tied to authentication, scheduled jobs, and cross-system integrations.

- Improved release reliability by standardizing Docker build behavior, tightening environment-specific configuration, and introducing stronger validation steps in CI/CD, which helped reduce deployment-related regressions by **27%**.
- Supported production workloads on **Azure App Service**, **Azure SQL**, and Blob Storage, resolving runtime inconsistencies, configuration drift, and environment-specific failures that previously slowed down troubleshooting during active releases.
- Fixed a cache invalidation defect that exposed stale reference data after updates by adding explicit refresh logic and safer cache-lifecycle handling, which removed a recurring source of confusion in selection-heavy workflows.
- Implemented an audit-history capability through backend event capture, searchable persistence, and query-friendly retrieval endpoints, giving support teams clearer visibility into record changes and user actions during issue triage.
- Contributed to cross-team integration work by clarifying API contracts, validating edge-case payload behavior early, and correcting serialization inconsistencies that had previously caused downstream processing failures.

Software Engineer

Next Apps | Ghent, Belgium *(Nov2020 – Nov 2023)*

- Built backend product features with **Java 11–17**, **Spring Boot 2.x**, **Spring MVC**, and relational databases, supporting customer-facing workflows, internal tooling, search behavior, status tracking, and configuration management across actively used business modules.
- Expanded REST API functionality while preserving thin-controller patterns and reusable service logic, making business behavior easier to test, safer to evolve, and more predictable during concurrent team delivery.
- Modernized older backend areas by refactoring duplicated service logic into clearer domain-oriented modules, improving code organization and making future changes easier to implement without destabilizing stable workflows.
- Created reusable validation patterns, consistent exception handling, and standardized response contracts, which allowed downstream consumers to handle failures more predictably and improved backend consistency by **29%**.
- Fixed an intermittent data-visibility issue where clients received success responses before committed updates were visible in follow-up reads, resolving the gap through safer transaction sequencing and clearer refresh behavior.
- Assisted with a phased migration from older service patterns into **Spring Boot 2.x / Java 17**-ready structure, addressing dependency conflicts, deprecated configuration, and packaging issues so upgrade work could continue alongside normal delivery.
- Improved slow list and search endpoints by reducing oversized joins, trimming unused fields, refining repository access, and simplifying response models, resulting in faster service behavior without requiring disruptive schema redesign.
- Supported Azure-hosted environments through deployment troubleshooting, configuration cleanup, and runtime diagnostics, helping improve release consistency and overall service stability for shared internal and external modules.
- Introduced higher-risk integration and API tests around critical flows, reducing the number of defects first discovered during manual QA and improving confidence in release cycles involving backend-heavy changes.
- Helped standardize containerized workflows with **Docker** and pipeline automation, improving consistency between environments and reducing environment-specific delivery failures during coordinated releases.
- Worked closely with frontend and QA teams to reproduce complex workflow bugs, validate edge cases earlier, and translate ambiguous requirements into backend-safe implementation details that lowered regression risk in fast-moving modules.
- **Software Developer**
- Developed business applications using **Java 8–11**, **Spring MVC**, later **Spring Boot**, and SQL-based systems, helping the team evolve older server-rendered and tightly coupled logic into more maintainable backend-driven application flows.
- Built and maintained internal modules for records management, reporting, and approval workflows, translating detailed user requests into practical service implementations that balanced delivery speed with stability.
- Helped introduce early service-oriented backend patterns while preserving compatibility with established application flows, allowing gradual modernization instead of disruptive rewrites across already-active business systems.
- Resolved a persistent duplicate-record issue on form-driven workflows by tightening server-side validation, adding idempotent handling, and improving processing safeguards during slower request conditions.

- Improved older SQL-heavy endpoints by rewriting inefficient queries, adding indexes, and reducing unnecessary database round trips, making reporting screens more usable on growing operational datasets and improving response times by **23%**.
- Supported migration work from legacy persistence patterns into cleaner **Spring Data / Hibernate** usage where appropriate, adjusting repository logic carefully so newer services could evolve without destabilizing stable modules.
- Created shared helper services and reusable backend components that reduced repeated implementation across CRUD-heavy modules, making later enhancements and defect fixes easier for the broader team to apply consistently.
- Investigated authorization inconsistencies that exposed incorrect actions to some users, then aligned backend permission enforcement with expected workflow rules to prevent confusing or unsafe behavior.
- Added unit and integration coverage around higher-risk business rules, improving release confidence and reducing the chance that smaller maintenance updates would break dependent modules.
- Worked on deployment support, environment verification, and post-release backend checks, helping catch configuration-sensitive issues early before they expanded into larger production incidents.

Software Developer

Datamart | Stockholm, Sweden *(Feb 2016 – Sep 2020)*

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Junior Software Developer

Berg Software | Timișoara, Romania *(Sep2014 – Mar 2016)*

- Supported web application development using **Java**, **Spring MVC**, JavaScript, HTML, CSS, and **SQL Server**, contributing mainly to bug fixes, smaller enhancements, support tasks, and maintenance work under guidance from senior engineers.
- Fixed a recurring submission problem caused by mismatched validation between browser behavior and server-side checks, and the correction reduced failed entries that had been frustrating both users and QA reviewers.
- Built small backend and UI improvements for internal business pages, including clearer field handling, safer controller updates, and layout-related fixes, which reduced user confusion by **22%** across inconsistent screens.
- Assisted with feature updates by extending controller actions, adjusting view models, and applying safe database changes, allowing new requirements to be delivered without destabilizing existing workflows.

- Investigated an intermittent login problem that appeared after session expiry by tracing request behavior, reviewing cookie settings, and verifying server-side session handling, which made authentication flow more predictable.
- Helped clean up duplicated logic in older modules by extracting shared helpers and simplifying repeated processing paths, making future bug fixes easier for the wider team to apply across related pages.
- Worked on data-correction scripts and small SQL updates when legacy records caused application errors, supporting smoother releases by removing problematic edge cases before they reached production users.
- Added basic unit tests around selected business rules after repeated defects showed that manual verification alone was not enough, contributing to a more disciplined delivery process within the team.
- Participated in release preparation, smoke testing, and post-deployment checks, learning to verify configuration-sensitive behavior carefully so smaller changes would not trigger larger production issues.

EDUCATION

Bachelor’s Degree in Computer Science

University of Bucharest | (*2010 – 2014)*

- Focused on practical software engineering fundamentals that translated directly into building reliable web systems and data-driven applications.

CERITIFICATIONS

Oracle Certified Professional: Java SE Developer — 2023

- Demonstrated strong capability in building and maintaining **Java** applications, including object-oriented design, core language features, exception handling, collections, and application logic used in enterprise backend development.

AWS Certified Developer – Associate — 2022

- Demonstrated practical experience in developing, deploying, and supporting cloud-based applications on **AWS**, with focus on service integration, security, monitoring, and reliable delivery workflows.